Gidion's Knot

By Johnna Adams

Setting: A 5th grade classroom in a public school in the Lake Forest suburb of Chicago.

INTRODUCTION

Gidion's Knot . . . a reference to a legendary chapter in the life of Alexander the Great in which he is tasked with unraveling several knots so tightly entangled that it is impossible to see how they are fastened. Since then, the phrase "Gordian Knot" has been used to describe a complex or unsolvable problem.

Gidion's Knot by Johnna Adams turns out to be as difficult to unravel as the Gordian one for which it's named. You see, this is a play about the death of a child. It is also a play about the right to freedom of expression and whether it is limited by society's needs. And it is a play about the support a mother must and will give her child. Ultimately it is the story of a confrontation between a mother and a teacher.

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CORRYN: I missed open house. So we never got to meet.

HEATHER: You're Gidion's mother.

CORRYN: You can call me Corryn. You sent a note home with my son. Asking to meet with me. . . . Telling me he was suspended.

HEATHER: I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry. I'm so very, very sorry.

CORRYN: The reason you suspended him? I'd really like to know. I've been wondering. Your note was vague. The voicemail was cryptic. I've been up for about 72 hours. I can't sleep. I can't sleep because I've been playing this conversation out over and over again in my mind, wondering how it will go. You were more vocal in these little fantasies. You contributed. You explained . . . I don't know why you . . . did this to him. I don't know what happened.

HEATHER: . . .

CORRYN: He looked devastated. When he handed me the note. He was shaking. He—

HEATHER: God! . . . oh god . . . I didn't think you'd keep the appointment. It never occurred to me that you would keep the appointment.

CORRYN: He's my son.

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HEATHER: I didn't think you'd still want to talk about—

CORRYN: About my son?

HEATHER: That it might be painful to. . . To talk about him so soon after his death. I'm really very sorry—

CORRYN: You've said so.

HEATHER: . . .

CORRYN: Thank you. . . . I'm sorry I missed open house. Gidion's father is dead. I'm a single mother. Getting a babysitter on a school night is like squeezing milk from stones. Do you have children?

HEATHER: No.

CORRYN: How long have you been teaching?

HEATHER: Two years. Maybe we should reschedule. Find a time when the principal can join us. You should be with family now.

CORRYN: I'm exactly where I should be. You sent a note home with my son. You suspended him. Five days.

HEATHER: Yes. You should take some time to grieve before . . . this. We all should take some time—

CORRYN: Who's Jake?

HEATHER: He's a boy in the sixth grade.

CORRYN: Is he one of the children that Gidion made angry? On Friday? The day he died? . . . There's a Jake on facebook who left comments on Gidion's facebook page over the weekend saying "You're a faggot" and "You're a lying faggot." After Gidion was dead, in fact, so-- . . . untimely.

HEATHER: He couldn't have known Gidion was dead. The kids didn't know until this morning. Jake's been troubled lately. It's out of character if he did that. . . Can I get you something to drink? The faculty lounge is just down the hall.

CORRYN: No thank you. I'm fine . . . Do you want to know what I do? You won't see this coming . . . I'm a teacher.

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HEATHER: What do you teach?

CORRYN: Literature. At Northwestern. In the graduate program. . . Jesus Christ. What the hell happened? I thought this would be largely a transactional exchange. I ask, you give. Even-- well, correct me if I'm wrong-- you have two years of professional experience, but, even if the circumstances around my son's suspension weren't . . . charged, let's say, by the fact of his death, I would expect the reasons for his suspension to have at least come up

HEATHER: . . . . *(Heather pulls out a key ring. She finds a key and unlocks a drawer. She takes out a folder covered in comic book superheroes and sets it on her desk.)*

CORRYN: What is it?

HEATHER: What got Gidion suspended. She offers the folder to Corryn. Corryn doesn't take it.

HEATHER: It's something Gidion wrote . . . A story.

CORRYN: You have got to be kidding me. You suspended my son over a story?

HEATHER: It's disturbing.

CORRYN: I have a feeling there are miles between what you and I find disturbing.

HEATHER: Read it and we'll see. *(Heather starts to leave.)*

CORRYN: Don't. . . I want you to explain things to me. I don't want to sit alone here. I didn't come here for that. I don't want to figure things out. I want them explained! I want you to read it to me.

HEATHER: It's not the way you want your son remembered.

CORRYN: You don't know what I want.

HEATHER: Trust me.

CORRYN: Read it.

HEATHER: I'm sorry. I honestly can't read that again. And certainly not out loud.

CORRYN: As bad as all that?

HEATHER: Yes.

CORRYN: As bad as facing what you did?

HEATHER: That's not fair. . . That is not fair. I know you're angry with me. I can't imagine how angry you must be with me. And you want to punish me. . . I don't know what went on in your

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house. . . Once he left this classroom my responsibility ended. This-- this is not a product of my classroom. He learned this *(gesturing to the folder)* in your house.

CORRYN: I can't read it. I need you to do this. . . Because it's in his handwriting . . . And I can't read his handwriting without seeing his suicide note in my hands. Please? *(Corryn holds the folder out to Heather. Heather takes it and opens it.)*

HEATHER: It began during a war, as things do. We all formed tribes and began killing the teachers. I cut Mr. Shawn apart myself with a hunting knife my grandfather gave me the last time he took me hunting. We needed his entrails for our weavers and our poets. I think Mr. Shawn was grateful. A group of sixth graders had caught him in the cafeteria earlier, by the vending machines, and cut out his eyes, flayed him. He was spitting blood up because of something they'd broken in him and I think he loved me for cutting him open. I took a broomstick out of the janitor's closet and nailed one end of his intestines to it and then rolled the rest of his intestines out of his stomach, twisting them around the broomstick-- they stretched more than 25 feet when I was done. Mr. Shawn had told me that intestines were that long in science class a month ago, but I didn't believe him until we started collecting them for the weavers and the poets. He was lucky. Most kids wouldn't have killed him first. I put the thick roll of Mr. Shawn's intestines over my shoulder and started walking to the gym, which is the room where we kept the weavers.

Around the corner in the hall outside the nurse's office, the nurse, Carole from the office and the fat principal were hanging from the walls by nails punched through their wrists and ankles and knees and shoulders. Their bodies were just gaping, empty bags. No entrails to salvage.

The broomstick was heavy and I had enough guts, so I made my way to the gym, where the weavers worked. Since the weavers started working, the gym stopped smelling like a gym and started smelling like a butchers' shop and a toilet. All those entrails being braided and woven. You wondered how the weavers could stand it, but when they changed into weavers, maybe they lost their sense of smell. We had been in home period, in Ms. Clark's room when the first weaver was chosen. We don't know by who, some think there are aliens on earth like the body snatchers and some think God did it. But whoever did it, in the middle of class this girl

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suddenly screamed and her eyes turned into balls of blue glass and her arms stretched out like poles and her hands grew new fingers and grew big. This was happening in other classes, but we didn't know that. And she started asking for entrails. Not to eat, but to make things with. So we put her and the others in the gym and they started making looms out of the janitor's supplies. And we started killing for them. We had to give the weavers what they needed. Some of us sort of hung back to see what the weavers were making from the teachers' entrails before we started killing and gutting. But when the first cloak was made and the first poet climbed the hill, I knew I had to kill however many teachers I needed to so that I could have one.

I gave a weaver my last pile of entrails and she tied them onto the ends of the other entrails I had brought her and started weaving. The cloth the weavers make from the teachers' entrails is like nothing you've ever seen. It's like a river and a taste of salt. It's like an ocean with fish moving through black water. When the weaver finished my gut-cloak she put it around my shoulders and I felt the pull. And I walked out of the building to the soccer field where the tribes who kept the first through third grade kids as slaves had made them build a mountain. And I climbed the mountain and joined the poets there. We watch the war and we write about the great deeds done or the horrors done. And that is how God remembers you-- the way we write you. And no other way. *(Heather shuts the folder and puts it in front of Corryn on a desk.)*

He was passing it around. To the other students. It's my responsibility to-- . . . I'm sure you understand. I can't imagine what it-- . . . . I don't think, at heart, that he-- . . . . Well. . . . I know this isn't all there was to him.

CORRYN: This is magnificent! This is wonderful writing. Strong. Fearless. Fierce. Brave. Cruel. Remarkable. This is a wonderful story. About art and its purpose. About man and divine judgement. Oh god. God, it's beautiful.

HEATHER: I disagree.

CORRYN: Why?

HEATHER: I have a responsibility to my students. To protect them.

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CORRYN: From what?

HEATHER: From things like this. Damaging things.

CORRYN: Poetry?

HEATHER: Hate-filled, poisonous attacks. He passed this around to a room full of children . . .

CORRYN: Oh, God. I put him here. Into a pit. Full of the unenlightened. Into the hands of the conventional. Who the hell are you to tell my son what not to write about?

HEATHER: His teacher.

CORRYN: What were you teaching him? How to disappear into some mold you wanted to pour him into?

HEATHER: This decision wasn't about him. It was about the other children. Their well-being. This is a fifth-grade classroom.

CORRYN: This is a small box. Full of smaller boxes. One of which you tried to keep my son in. And when he couldn't fit inside it, he shot himself in the head. Over not fitting in a box cut to your dimensions. I blame you for this. He wanted to be a writer. He was going to be one.

He didn't die because of what he wrote, or because you suspended him. He died because he couldn't face telling me about it-- . . . god damn it . . . He could have told me this. God. I'm not a good mother. . . There are so many things that could go wrong-- so many ways I could ruin things-- but this? This? This was my good mother moment. What happened? He could have told me this. I would have told him: "This is magnificent. You are a poet. You're perfect. They're wrong." My good mother moment. The one time-- the one time I would have been the mother he needed and not just the one he got.

HEATHER: . . .

CORRYN: I don't know what I did to make him think he couldn't tell me. . . This. *(Motioning to the folder)* It's based on a story I used to tell him when he was little. About the Great Poet's war. Once upon a time in the green hills of ancient Gaul, two warring clans met on the battlefield of Ballycrief. Each clan had a master poet and a poet's apprentice. And they sent their poets to the top of the hill. So they could see" Because men aren't afraid of dying, but they are afraid of not being remembered.

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HEATHER: . . .

CORRYN: Sign this. *(taking the suspension notice out of her purse)* You sent this home with him. I'm supposed to meet with you and get it signed. Unless it is no longer important . . . I was grading papers when he gave it to me. I knew it was something big. He couldn't look at me. He was shaking. I saw what it was and told him everything would be all right. Asked him if he wanted to talk about it. He shook his head no. He went up to his room. I didn't hear him go into the garage. I called him to come down for dinner. He didn't answer so I started up the stairs to go get him and I heard the gun shot. I thought he was upstairs still and I couldn't imagine-- I called out again and told him to stay in his room and then I went into the garage. He had taken garbage bags-- the ones for gathering dead leaves, and taped them in a large rectangle on the floor. Like a tarp. But, he didn't understand. Because he put the gun under his chin. So, nothing. . . nothing landed on the tarp. So. He didn't leave behind the tidy mess he thought he would.

HEATHER: . . .

CORRYN: He left a note. *(takes another slip of paper from her purse)*

HEATHER: . . .

CORRYN: "I've gone to stand with the poets."

HEATHER: . . . That's beautiful.

CORRYN: When someone tells you what her child's suicide note says, you aren't supposed to say "that's beautiful." It really isn't appropriate. But you said it. Because you felt it . . . Thank you.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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NOTE: *More about the Gordion Knot myth can be found here http://www.mythencyclopedia.com/Fi-Go/Gordian-Knot.html*